Help Suit Game Try

Print Page Download PDF

8.8k Shares

Email Share Post

A help suit game try may occur after an auction begins 1♥ : 2♥ or 1♠ : 2♠.

When opener holds game-invitational values (15-17 points or 6 losers), she can bid a new suit at the cheapest level to say, "Partner, I'm interested in game, but I need help in this suit. Please bid game if you have an appropriate holding."

Partnership styles vary, but a help suit typically shows a 3-4 card suit with exactly one of the top three honors. In losing trick count parlance, this equals 2 - 2.5 losers. Examples:

- Qxx(x)
- Kxx(x)
- KJx(x)
- Axx(x)

The help suit game try does not require an alert, as long as it shows 3+ cards.

Help Suit vs. Long Suit Game Tries

Before going further, it's worth discussing the syntax of game tries.

- In traditional bidding, a new suit at the 3-level constituted a **long** suit game try. This required opener to hold at least a 4-card suit. In modern bidding, shorter length requirements have become commonplace due to practicality. Hence the 3-card examples above.
- "The Encyclopedia of Bridge" defines the HSGT as a **weak** suit game try. And in "25 Bridge Conventions You Should Know", Barbara Seagram and Marc Smith define a help suit as "anything from three or four small cards to Qxxx - any suit with at least two losers."

  At the risk of contradicting two venerable books, I have suggested roughly 2 - 2.5 losers because I believe it to be more practical. (The risk of a potential misnomer aside.) When you make and reject game tries with xxx, the opponents have a screaming indicator about what to lead.

Responses

Applying losing trick count, responder should bid game with 0 - 2 losers in the suit. And she should sign off in 3♥/♠ with 3 losers - i.e. a worthless tripleton like Jxx or xxx.

There is one dicey holding worth mentioning - Qxx(x). In my opinion, Qxx(x) equals 2.5 losers, although many players treat it as only 2. I've always had trouble accepting this. How can Axx and Qxx be valued the same way? Therefore, partnerships should agree if/when Qxx(x) can constitute a HSGT; and conversely, if it's worth a jump to game by responder. Good interior cards, e.g. QT9, or perhaps good overall strength and/or shape, might affect the decision.

A non-exhausive list of responder's possible holdings in the help suit:

Holding	# Losers	Responder's action
Void	0 losers	Bid game
AK	0 losers	
x	1 loser	
Ax	1 loser	
KJT	1.5 losers	
xx	2 losers	Bid game
Jx	2 losers	
Qx	2 losers	
QJx	2 losers	
Kxx	2 losers	
Axx	2 losers	
xxx	3 losers	Sign off in 3♥/♠
Txxx	3 losers	
Jxxx	3 losers	

Examples

Opener	Responder
♠6	♠AJ8
♥AKT53	♥987
♦KQJ	♦A763
♣Q743	♣962

Opener	Responder
1♥	2♥
3♣ (1)	3♥ (2)
Pass	

1. A HSGT in clubs
2. Signing off with a poor club holding, despite 9 HCP

Opener	Responder
♠KT9	♠QJ5
♥KJT632	♥Q94
♦AK	♦6543
♣72	♣A54

Opener	Responder
1♥	2♥
2♠ (1)	4♥ (2)
Pass	

1. A HSGT in spades
2. Bidding game with a help suit control

Opener	Responder
♠AJT62	♠9754
♥T86	♥KQ2
♦A75	♦6
♣AK	♣J8543

Opener	Responder
1♠	2♠
3♦ (1)	4♠ (2)
Pass	

1. A HSGT in diamonds
2. Only one loser

Other Considerations

Giving extra information to the defense

A potential drawback to help suit game tries is that they help inform the defense's opening lead.

- When responder rejects a help suit game try, the defense might be more motivated to attack that suit on opening lead.
- When responder accepts a help suit game try, the defense might shy away from leading a standard 4th best from something like KJxx.

Using hearts as a help suit

After 1♠ : 2♠, a 3♥ rebid may or may not be a help suit game try. This requires partnership discussion:

Opener	Responder
♠AJT62	♠KQ8
♥AQ65	♥KT73
♦7	♦J65
♣A96	♣532

Opener	Responder
1♠	2♠
3♥ (1)	4♥ (2)
Pass	

1. Natural and forcing with 15+ points
2. Bidding the heart game with 4-card support

This sequence is natural because a 4-4 fit is often preferable to a 5-3 fit. These two hands play better with hearts as trumps, because the spades can be used to pitch club losers from dummy. Declarer can draw trumps in three rounds, run the spades, and then ruff a club in dummy for an overtrick. With spades as trumps, 10 tricks are the limit.

Note that this problem does not occur when the auction begins 1♥ : 2♥ and opener rebids 2♠. This is because responder should not be holding 4 spades and 3 hearts. With that distribution, he should initially reply 1♠, not 2♥. So there is no need for opener to probe for a secondary 4-4 spade fit.

Lastly, the adoption of help suit game tries means that opener's 3♥/♠ rebids ask for help in the trump suit:

Opener	Responder
♠AK6	♠J82
♥J8532	♥T74
♦3	♦KQJ2
♣AKJ3	♣Q65

Opener	Responder
1♥	2♥
3♥ (1)	Pass (2)

1. My hearts are lousy

2. Mine too!

Help suit game tries by responder

Partnerships may also choose to agree to use help suit game tries if opener expresses support for responder's major. For example:

Opener	Responder
♠A962	♠J8
♥J852	♥AT94
♦3	♦A642
♣AK53	♣Q65

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♥
2♥	3♦
4♥	Pass

Short suit game tries

As an alternative to help suit game tries, see short suit game tries.

See also

- Short Suit Game Try
  The artificial bid of a short side suit as a major-suit game try.